faith, and exhibiting precisely those characteristics that have both preserved Hindu India and held it captive.

This was my first encounter with what was at that time a comparatively rare species: the ideologue who lives in denial of the real – as opposed to the mythical – past.

Readers familiar with my earlier books will know that I have argued that the modern era of Indian historiography and Indian studies began with the British Raj. As I have defined it earlier, imperialism is the exploitation of one people by another but it is also a two-way street, and one of the by-products of British rule in India was cross-fertilisation and the importation of new ideas – perfectly encapsulated in the person of one man and the institution he founded: the jurist Sir William 'Oriental' Jones and the Asiatic Society of Bengal.

Founded in Calcutta on 15 January 1784, the Asiatic Society of Bengal was Asia's first learned society, modelled on the Royal Society in London (of which the present president, Sir Venkatraman Ramakrishnan, just happens to be a Nobel Prize-winning scientist born in the temple city of Chidambaram in Tamil Nadu). At the Asiatic Society's inaugural meeting William Jones read out a thirty-three-page *Discourse* that he had prepared on his voyage out to India, a 'grand and stupendous' plan to enquire into man and nature in general and Asia in particular. Fluent in thirteen languages and capable of understanding another twenty-eight, Jones was the very epitome of the European Enlightenment, the new way of looking at the world that the German philosopher Immanuel Kant defined in the year of Jones's arrival in India as 'the emancipation of the human consciousness from an immature state of ignorance'.

This emancipation came about in Northern Europe as the result of a combination of factors ranging from capitalism and printing presses to coffee-houses and journalism. It was one of those rare moments of conjunction in human history when a paradigm shift in reasoning takes place. Ancient